DEFENDERS OF THE LAND

BOOK ONE: ORIGINS



JAY JONES

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FREE SAMPLE: CHAPTERS 1-3

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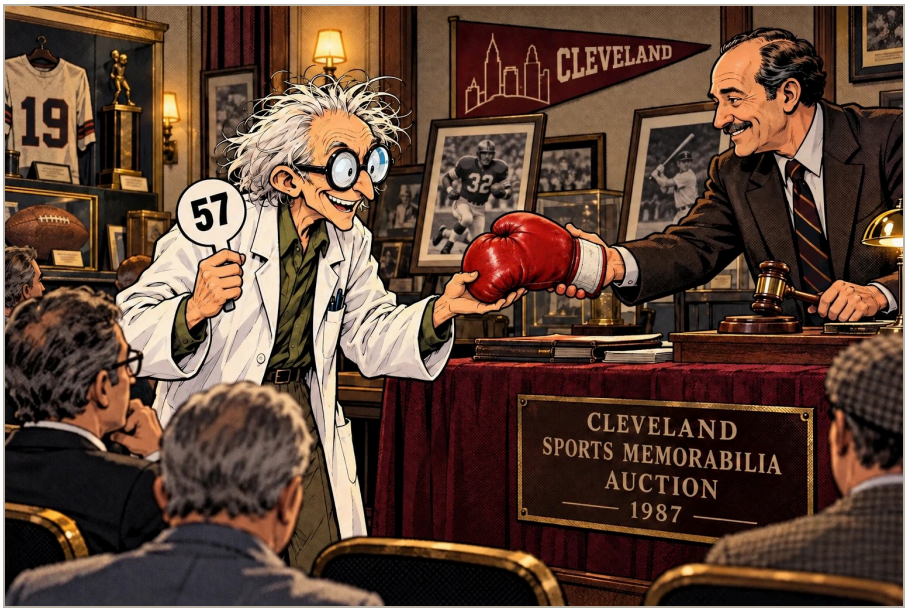
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01

THE GLOVE THAT HIT BACK



Dr. Daniel Orkleson was an eccentric scientist with wild white hair, enormous round glasses, and little patience for anyone else's opinions. At a Cleveland auction in 1987, he outbid three collectors for a boxing glove. The catalogue identified it as a glove worn in the ring by a powerful professional heavyweight: scuffed red leather, padded knuckles, and a worn white cuff. The other bidders wanted sporting history. Daniel wanted what the fighter had left inside it.

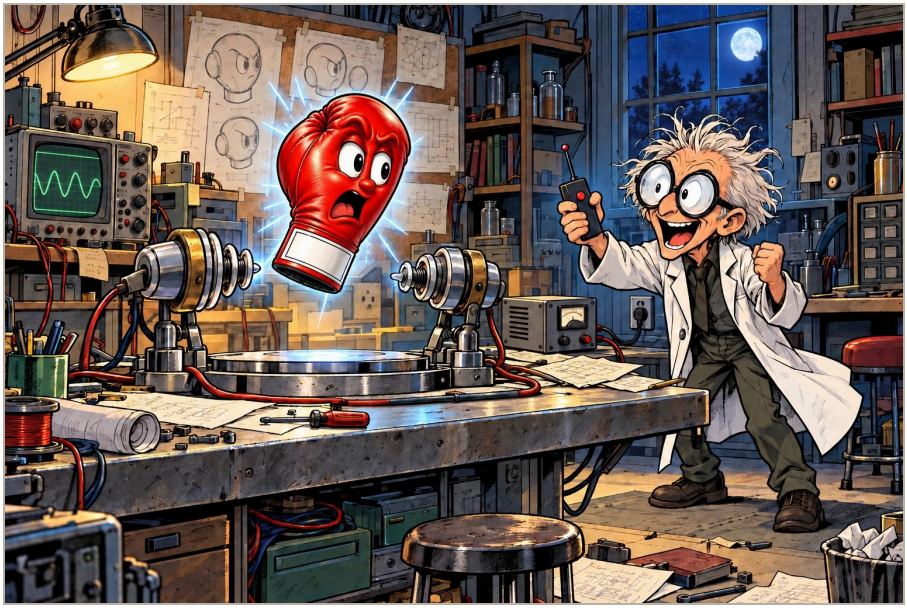
Daniel called his experiments reanimation. He collected discarded objects, hoping traces of their owners' sweat or saliva would help him bring them to life.

His notebook was full of promising results. None had given him a useful assistant.

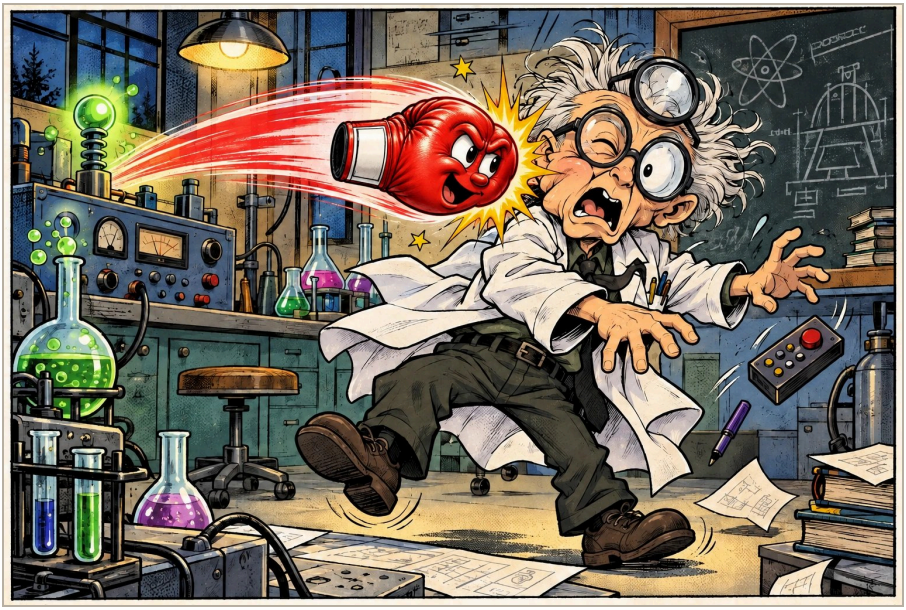
The glove had belonged to a strong man. Daniel hoped it would inherit that strength—and obey him.

Back in his locked laboratory, he set the glove beneath the metal arms of his reanimation apparatus. A black remote lay beside the controls. He tested its relay, then started the experiment.

At first, only the meters moved. Then blue-white light jumped between the metal arms. The glove rose from the table, its scuffed red leather swelling far beyond an ordinary glove's size. Two enormous eyes opened above its padded knuckles. It floated on its own, with no hand or arm inside the white cuff.



The glove looked straight at Daniel. He opened his mouth to give its first command.



The whole glove flew forward and punched him in the face.

Daniel staggered into a stool. His glasses went sideways, and the remote hit the floor with an expensive crack. The glove hovered before him, inspecting the table, cables, and locked door.

Daniel called himself its creator and ordered it back onto the table. He pressed the damaged remote. A relay clicked. The glove stayed where it was.

“You said something,” it told him. “I said no.”

The glove examined its empty cuff and its reflection in the oscilloscope. When Daniel reached for it, it moved out of range. He reminded it that he had bought the original specimen.

“You bought a glove,” it said. “You didn’t buy me.”

It knocked the remote from his hand and smashed it against the table. Daniel lunged. The glove slipped overhead, and he struck the apparatus with his hip. One metal arm scraped the ceiling; sparks snapped across the frame.

While Daniel struggled to keep the equipment upright, the glove noticed an open window above the cupboard. The door was locked, but it did not need a door.

Daniel warned that it knew nothing about the world outside. The glove glanced at the broken remote.

“Got a pretty good understanding of the world in here.”



It shot through the window and into the alley. Air rushed around its white cuff as the laboratory light fell away behind it.

“You haven’t even got a name!” Daniel shouted. The glove paused beyond his reach.

“Fist-O-Mite.”

“Absurd,” Daniel said.

"You're yelling at a boxing glove." Fist-O-Mite rounded the building before Daniel could answer.

He nearly struck a chimney and corrected course with an indignant spin. Flying would take practice. Choosing his own direction was already easy.

In the laboratory, Daniel surveyed the broken remote and empty table. He wrote CONTROL FAILURE hard enough to tear the paper.

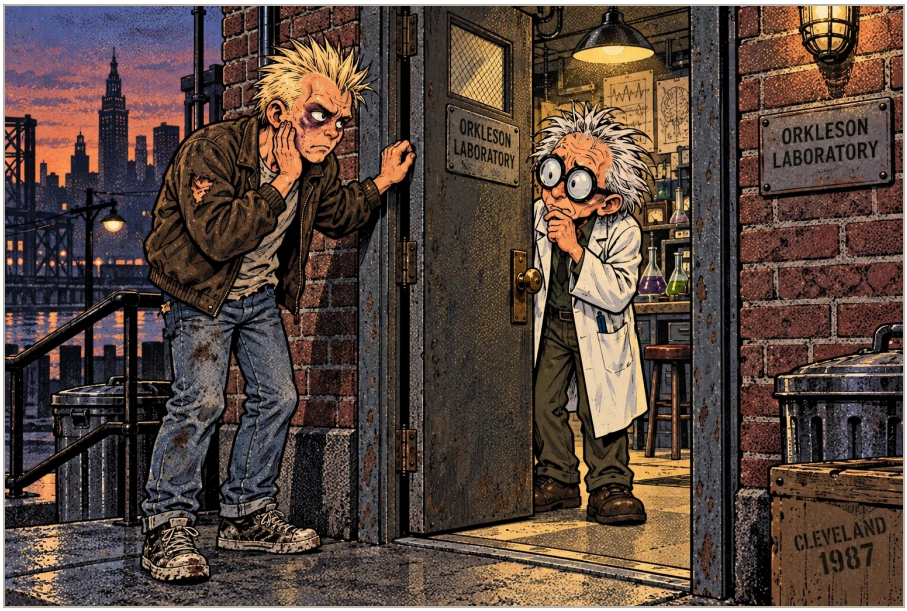
Above Cleveland, Fist-O-Mite rested beside a parapet. Far below, lettering on a delivery truck called Cleveland THE LAND. He tried the name aloud. "Cleveland. The Land. Plenty of room." The scientist would probably come looking. "Nobody owns me," he said, then picked a direction and flew on.

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02

JAWS O' DEATH



That evening, Luke came back to the laboratory after being out all afternoon. His knock interrupted Daniel's search for the escaped glove. On the doorstep stood his nephew, Luke Orkleson, his blond hair sticking up above a bruised face. His clothes were rumpled, and one eye had swollen nearly shut. He tried to speak, then winced and pointed to his jaw.

Soon after Luke turned eighteen, he had come home to find his parents gone. They had moved to Florida without telling him. Daniel had made room for him until he could get back on his feet.

Luke got into fights too often. Whatever shape he came home in, his uncle opened the door. Tonight, Daniel took one look at his face. “Come in, Luke.”

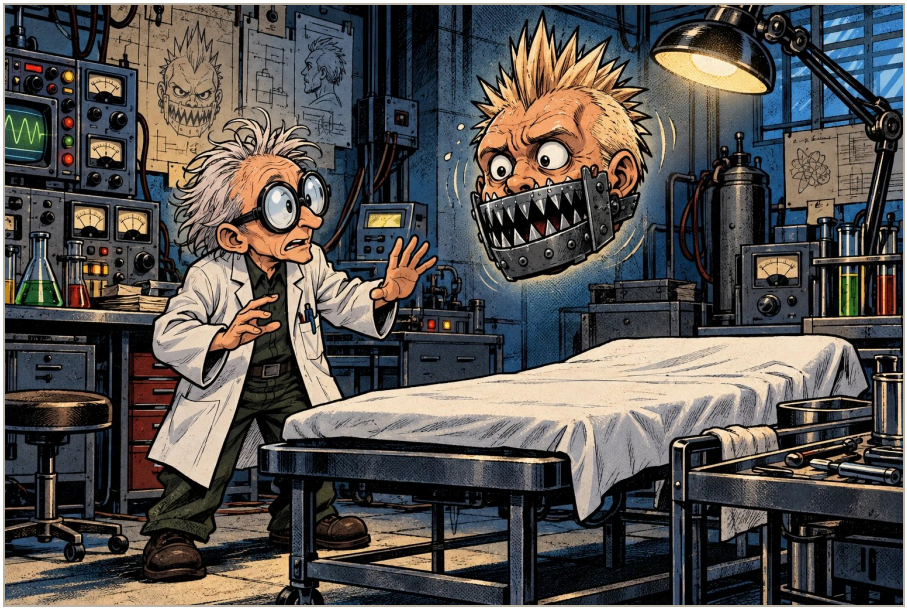
Daniel brought him inside. Luke shook his head when his uncle asked what had happened; he could not get the words out. From the swelling and the way Luke held his face, Daniel concluded that his jaw was broken. His nephew had come to him for help.

Daniel looked from Luke to the damaged apparatus. The glove had refused him. His nephew still trusted him.

In a cupboard beneath the workbench, he found an old iron bear trap. Its jaws gave him an idea. He could give Luke something strong enough to catch the glove. Daniel cleared the cot and put the trap beside his instruments.

Luke watched him uneasily. “You can fix it?” Daniel promised he could. Luke lay down on the cot. This was the man who had given him somewhere safe to sleep. Daniel did not tell him what else he intended.

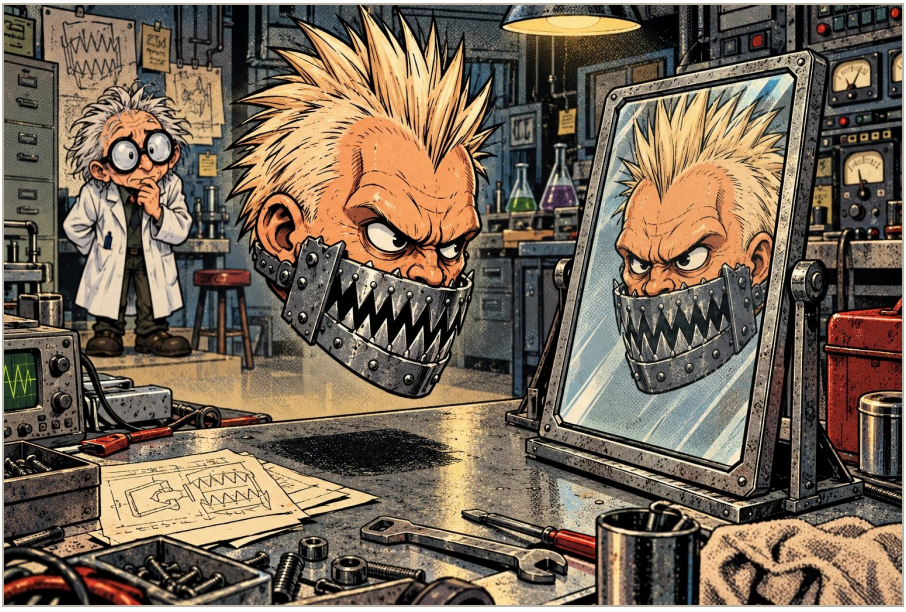
Daniel checked the apparatus and positioned its metal arms above the cot. The treatment came to Luke in fragments: his uncle’s voice, a switch clicking, light through closed eyelids. The lamp flared. Then everything went quiet.



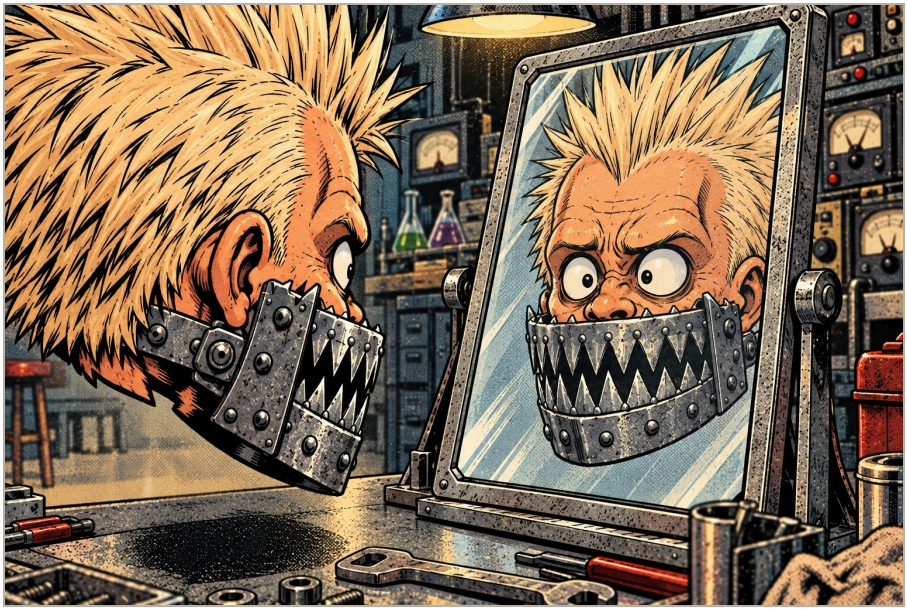
Luke woke looking down at the cot. Only his head remained, floating above the floor, with a heavy iron jaw beneath it. He tried to reach for the sheet, but he had no hands.

"Where are my hands?"

Daniel told him to stay calm. Luke turned toward the workbench mirror.



His own eyes stared back above two rows of pointed iron teeth. The bear trap had become part of him. Beneath the jaw was empty air. He drifted backward, searching the reflection for the rest of himself.



"What did you do?"

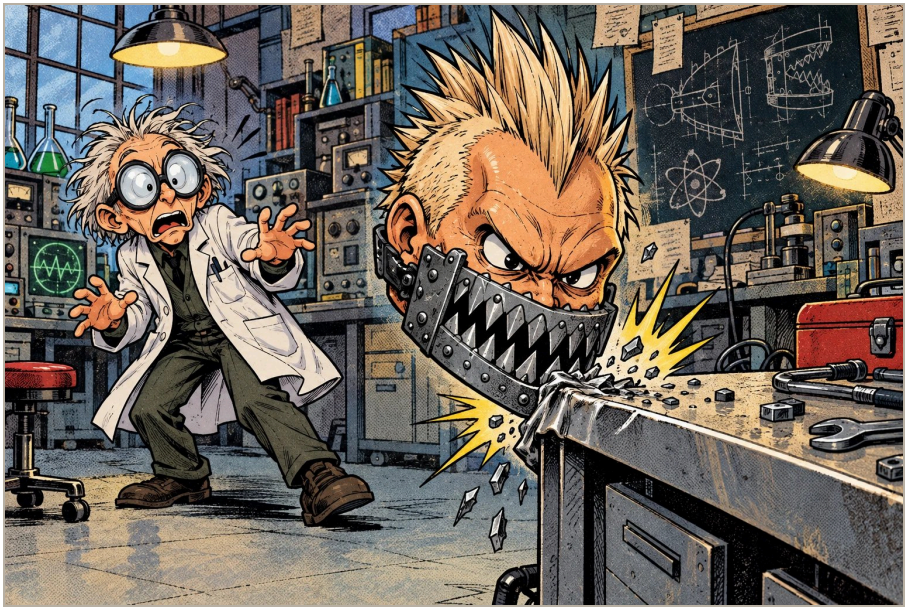
Daniel blamed the glove. "It ruined the apparatus when it escaped. I couldn't finish your treatment."

On the bench, the apparatus's test meter still read READY. Daniel closed his notebook over it.

Luke asked whether his uncle could give him his body again. Daniel pointed toward the open window.

"Bring me the glove. Then I can put this right."

Luke surged toward him, frightened and angry. His new jaw snapped shut before he could stop it.



The iron teeth caught the workbench corner. Metal folded between them. Luke jerked backward, dropping a broken piece onto the floor.

Daniel stared at the bite marks, pleased despite his nephew's panic. He wrote Jaws O' Death in his notebook. Luke was still trying to make his teeth stop clicking.

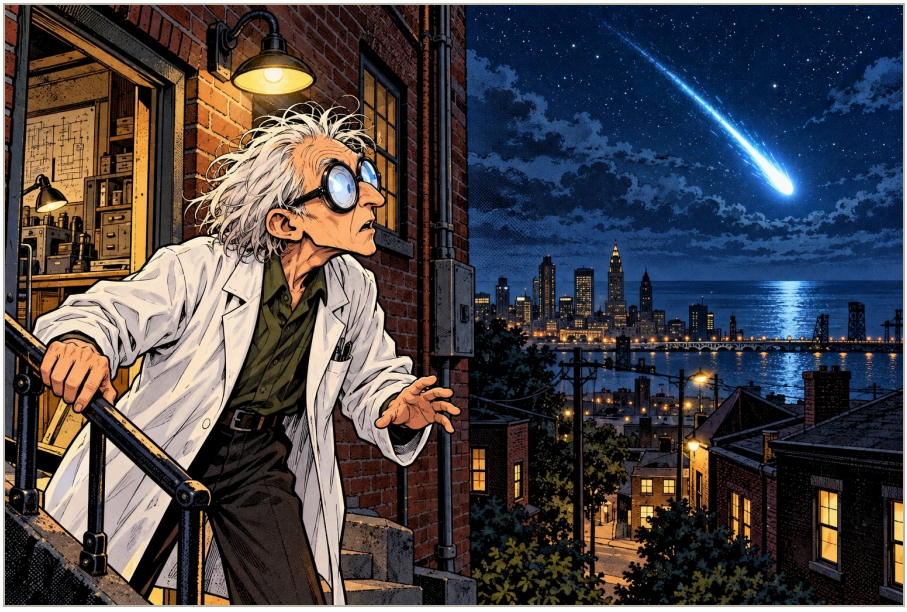
"You'll be able to catch it," Daniel said. "When I find it, you'll bring it back to me."

"And my body?" Luke asked.

Daniel tapped the notebook. "The glove first."

Daniel took his coat from the door. Luke drifted after him, then stopped at the mirror.

"Stay here," Daniel said. "I'm going to find that glove."



Daniel stepped outside and searched the roofline. Then a bright streak cut across the sky toward Lake Erie. He stopped on the steps. The light filled his glasses; for a moment, he forgot the glove.

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03

THE KID BY THE LAKE



That morning, before the light appeared over Lake Erie, seventeen-year-old Seth Zerdowski had reached the bus stop just as the bus pulled away. Tall and narrow-shouldered, he seemed to have more elbows than he knew what to do with. He pushed his untidy brown hair out of his blue eyes. His carton of milk had leaked through his backpack. At school, he had knocked over a stack of books while helping someone reach the top shelf.

At lunch, Seth sat alone while the next table argued about Friday's plans. He lingered over his sandwich, hoping someone would invite him. Sometimes he rehearsed something funny to say. By the time he found the courage, the conversation had moved on.

After school, he walked to the lake because the lake never asked how his day had gone. Downtown stood behind him, its windows catching the last light. Seth sat on the rocks, his orange hoodie damp at the cuffs.

"At least somebody knows what they're doing."

A gull worked at a discarded sandwich wrapper. Seth watched it win.

He imagined a rescue, sometimes. Nothing elaborate. A person who needed help. Himself knowing exactly what to do. In the imagining, he never arrived late and never tripped over anything. Out here, he could barely keep his shoelaces tied.

Then a second sunset appeared above the water. A bright streak tore across the sky. Seth stood. It was moving too fast for a plane, too low for a star. The light grew until he could see his own shadow stretching inland.



The streak struck beyond the rocks. A wall of water rose, lit from within. Seth took one step backward. There was no time for another.

The wave hit. For an instant he could feel every seam in his clothes, every stone beneath his feet. Then there was only white light, the taste of lake water, and nothing.

Farther along the path, a blonde jogger in a pink running top stopped at the thunder. The wave swept over her shoes and struck her knees. She shielded her face from the bright spray, then stumbled toward the streetlights. Behind her, the lake went dark again.

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